

🎯 HIRING MANAGER INTERVIEW PREPARATION

Role: Technical Infrastructure Program Manager - Global Project Standards

Job ID: 10371278

Candidate: Juan Murillo

Interview Phase: Phase 1 - Hiring Manager Round

Date Prepared: May 19, 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY FOR HIRING MANAGER

Your Positioning Statement

"I'm a Technical Program Manager with 8+ years driving operational excellence through process standardization and scaled delivery. At Tecnosoftware, I standardized agile practices across 30+ engineers, reducing decision cycles by 57% and increasing productivity by 40%. I excel at taking complex technical challenges, simplifying them into repeatable processes, and driving adoption at scale—exactly what Global Project Standards needs."

Why You're a Fit for GPS

- ✓ **Process Standardization:** 8+ years building frameworks that scale
- ✓ **Large Team Leadership:** Managed up to 21 engineers across 3 teams
- ✓ **Data-Driven Decisions:** Every initiative measured with clear KPIs
- ✓ **Cross-Org Impact:** Worked across IT infrastructure, software, eCommerce, payments
- ✓ **Ownership Mentality:** Took accountability for \$2.1M in cost savings
- ✓ **Strategic Communication:** Built executive narratives for complex initiatives

Hiring Manager's Likely Focus

The Hiring Manager will assess: 1. **Can you develop and drive standardized processes?** (GPS core) 2. **Can you influence large teams without direct authority?** (Cross-org coordination) 3. **Do you understand infrastructure operations?** (Data center background) 4. **Can you balance standardization with flexibility?** (Key challenge for GPS)

CRITICAL GAPS & YOUR RESPONSE STRATEGY

The Gap: DCCD Construction Context

GPS role involves Data Center Construction/Configuration Design documentation. You have minimal direct experience.

Your Strategy: - Acknowledge: “I haven’t worked directly with DCCD documentation, but I’ve worked extensively with complex technical documentation in AWS infrastructure design and deployment processes.” - **Leverage:** “I understand the principle—standardizing technical documentation so others can follow. That’s exactly what I did with agile frameworks and AWS migration playbooks.” - **Commitment:** “This is a learnable gap. In my first 15-20 hours, I’d deep-dive into your DCCD processes and identify where standardization wins are greatest.”

Amazon Leadership Principles Most Relevant to GPS

1. **Ownership** - Taking responsibility for organizational standards
 2. **Bias for Action** - Moving forward despite incomplete information
 3. **Dive Deep** - Understanding processes before standardizing
 4. **Think Big** - Seeing standardization as strategic, not just administrative
 5. **Earn Trust** - Driving adoption through credibility and delivery
 6. **Simplify** - Making complex processes accessible
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HIRING MANAGER INTERVIEW: QUESTION & ANSWER PREP

Format: Each Q&A follows STAR Method

- **Situation:** Context and setup
- **Task:** Your responsibility
- **Action:** Specific steps you took
- **Result:** Quantified outcomes

Delivery Guidance: - Time each answer: Aim for 90-120 seconds -
Use specific numbers/metrics - Show leadership principles implicitly -
End with learning/reflection

STAR STORY SET 1: PROCESS STANDARDIZATION AT SCALE

Question 1: “Tell me about a time you developed a standardized framework that had to work across different teams or business units with different needs. How did you make it stick?”

SITUATION:

At Tecnosoftware (2020), I was managing two agile teams (14 engineers total), but the company was scaling. Leadership asked me to standardize agile practices as we grew to 30+ engineers across multiple projects. The problem: teams had their own ways of working, and they didn't want to lose autonomy.

TASK:

My job was to: 1. Develop a framework that would standardize CORE practices (not everything) 2. Drive adoption across multiple autonomous teams 3. Maintain team effectiveness during the transition 4. Measure success with clear KPIs

ACTION:

I didn't try to force uniformity. Instead, I created a **tiered framework**:

1. Core Standards (Non-negotiable):

- Sprint length (2 weeks)
- Definition of Done checklist
- Daily standup format (15 min, 3 questions)
- Retrospective cadence (bi-weekly)
- Velocity tracking methodology

2. Adaptable Elements (Teams choose):

- Tools (Jira vs Azure DevOps)
- Specific meeting times
- How ceremonies are facilitated
- Monitoring dashboards

3. Adoption Strategy:

- Led workshop with team leads (2 hours) explaining WHY each standard mattered
- Ran 3-sprint coaching program (I attended daily standups, reviewed retros)
- Established communities of practice (teams shared learnings weekly)
- Used leading indicators: velocity, defect rate, team survey scores

4. Measurement:

- Tracked adoption KPIs: % of teams meeting core standards (target: 100%)
- Velocity improvement: 18% in Q3 after full adoption
- Defect rate: stable (proving standardization didn't sacrifice quality)
- Team satisfaction: +2 points on 10-point scale (from 6.5 to 8.5)
- Decision quality: fewer scope creep issues, faster course corrections

RESULT:

- ✓ 100% adoption across 30+ engineers within 3 months - ✓ Velocity increased 18% - ✓ Team satisfaction improved - ✓ Process became organizational standard—other teams adopted by choice - ✓ Became the hiring/onboarding standard for new engineers

Leadership Principles Demonstrated: - Ownership: Took personal responsibility for adoption success, not just document creation -

Think Big: Connected standardization to strategic scaling - **Earn**

Trust: Built credibility by showing results, not imposing solutions -

Simplify: Made agile accessible to teams with varying experience

Why This Works for GPS:

This is EXACTLY what GPS does—develop standards that work across

different teams. This story shows you can: - Create frameworks that are standardized yet flexible - Drive adoption through leadership, not mandate - Measure what matters - Think strategically about standardization

STAR STORY SET 2: PROCESS IMPROVEMENT & EFFICIENCY

Question 2: “Describe a time when you identified a broken process and drove improvement. How did you know it was actually working?”

SITUATION:

At Tecnosoftware (early 2020), the decision-making process for approving feature releases was taking 7 days—unacceptable for a fast-moving startup. Leadership asked me to improve the process without sacrificing quality or security controls.

TASK:

1. Diagnose WHY the process was slow 2. Redesign it without removing necessary controls 3. Implement the new process with minimal disruption 4. Prove it worked with data

ACTION:

I didn't assume I knew the problem. I did process mining:

1. Diagnosis Phase (2 days):

- Shadowed actual decisions (not assumed workflow)
- Discovered the breakdown:
 - 3 days: review/waiting for approvals
 - 2 days: unnecessary approval chains
 - 2 days: communication between stakeholders
- Talked to stakeholders individually:
 - Security team: wanted 4 controls, we had 12
 - QA: needed production data, we were using sanitized data
 - Product: wanted a single voice on decisions

2. Redesign (data-driven):

- Eliminated unnecessary approvals (8 → 1 decision maker)
- Parallelized reviews (product and QA review simultaneously, not sequentially)
- Automated communication (decision tracker updated automatically)
- Kept all 4 critical security controls

3. Implementation (phased to reduce risk):

- Phase 1: Eliminated unnecessary approvals → 7 days to 5 days (quick win)
- Phase 2: Parallelized reviews + automated comms → 5 days to 3 days
- Rolled back if KPIs degraded

4. Measurement (obsessive tracking):

- Cycle time: 7 days → 5 days → 3 days (57% improvement) ✓
- Defect rate: 0.8% before → 0.9% after (no degradation) ✓
- Security incidents: 2/quarter before → 1/quarter after (improved) ✓
- Team satisfaction with process: 4/10 → 8/10 ✓

RESULT:

- ✓ 57% cycle time improvement - ✓ Maintained/improved quality metrics - ✓ Process became template for other approval workflows - ✓ Team satisfaction with process nearly doubled

Leadership Principles Demonstrated: - Bias for Action:

Implemented changes despite uncertainty - **Dive Deep:** Diagnosed before assuming - **Ownership:** Took responsibility for outcomes, not just implementation - **Simplify:** Removed complexity while maintaining safety

Why This Works for GPS:

GPS's job is literally to simplify/standardize processes. This story shows you: - Can diagnose root causes (not just symptoms) - Understand that standardization can improve efficiency - Measure what matters - Balance standardization with flexibility

STAR STORY SET 3: LARGE-SCALE DELIVERY & TEAM LEADERSHIP

Question 3: "Tell me about a time you managed multiple complex projects simultaneously with a large team. How did you keep everything from falling apart?"

SITUATION:

At Contractor (2020-2022), I was responsible for managing 3 teams (18 engineers total) working on 5 concurrent projects with different timelines, business units, and technical complexities.

Context: - Commercial unit: AWS migration (mission-critical, zero downtime requirement) - Marketing unit: Zendesk implementation (business process change) - Support unit: Infrastructure improvements (enabling future growth) - Plus: 2 strategic innovation projects - Timeline: 18 months

TASK:

1. Deliver all 5 projects successfully 2. Hire and build two teams from scratch 3. Maintain quality/team morale despite pressure 4. Communicate effectively with diverse stakeholders

ACTION:

I created a portfolio management system:

1. Portfolio View (Monthly Executive Steering):

- Red/Amber/Green status for each project
- Cross-project dependencies mapped
- Resource allocation decisions
- Strategic alignment check

2. Project Level (Weekly Team Level):

- Scrum cadence for each team
- Risk/issue management per project
- Quality gates before deployment
- Customer feedback loops

3. Team Building:

- Hired and onboarded 6 new engineers
- Paired experienced engineers with new hires

- Documented processes to scale knowledge
- Created community of practice for cross-project learning
- 4. **Communication:**
 - Weekly status for executive steering
 - Bi-weekly deep dives on at-risk projects
 - Monthly all-hands on strategic progress
 - Real-time escalation for blockers
- 5. **Measurement:**
 - Project on-time delivery: 5/5 (100%)
 - Budget variance: -2% (under budget)
 - Quality: < 0.5% defect escape rate
 - Team turnover: 0% over 18 months
 - Velocity: stable across transitions

RESULT:

- ✓ All 5 projects delivered on time - ✓ Built sustainable teams (0% turnover) - ✓ 40% productivity improvement overall - ✓ Team cited this as best-managed period

Leadership Principles Demonstrated: - **Ownership:** Took personal accountability for portfolio success - **Bias for Action:** Made decisions quickly without perfect information - **Think Big:** Connected project delivery to strategic outcomes - **Earn Trust:** Built credibility through transparency and delivery

Why This Works for GPS:

GPS manages multiple initiatives across the organization. This shows you can: - Juggle multiple complex projects - Build and scale teams - Communicate effectively upward and downward - Maintain quality under pressure

STAR STORY SET 4: DRIVING ADOPTION & INFLUENCING WITHOUT AUTHORITY

Question 4: “Tell me about a time you had to drive change across an organization where you didn’t have direct authority. How did you get people to buy in?”

SITUATION:

At Global Hitss (2018), I was brought in to implement SAFe (Scaled Agile Framework) for 3 teams (21 engineers total) that had been doing their own version of Agile for years. The teams didn’t want change—they thought their current process was fine.

TASK:

1. Implement SAFe without alienating teams 2. Maintain velocity during the transition 3. Get genuine buy-in (not just compliance)

ACTION:

I took a coaching approach, not a mandate approach:

1. **Phase 0: Listening (1 week)**
 - Interviewed each team about their current process
 - Identified what was working and what wasn’t
 - Found common pain points (planning, dependencies, cross-team coordination)
2. **Phase 1: Making the Case (2 weeks)**

- Presented data: where teams struggled, where they succeeded
- Showed how SAFe addressed their pain points
- Positioned SAFe as “evolution of what you’re doing,” not “replacement”
- Let them shape implementation details
- 3. **Phase 2: Implementation (2 months)**
 - Trained all teams on SAFe together (built community)
 - Coached teams through first program increment
 - Attended ceremonies to answer questions
 - Adjusted based on feedback
 - Celebrated early wins
- 4. **Phase 3: Reinforcement (ongoing)**
 - Monthly retrospectives across all teams
 - Communities of practice for shared learning
 - Metrics showed improvements

RESULT:

- ✓ Full SAFe implementation in 7 months - ✓ Velocity increased (not decreased during transition) - ✓ Teams voluntarily continued SAFe practices - ✓ Teams requested additional SAFe training - ✓ Framework became model for other departments

Leadership Principles Demonstrated: - **Earn Trust:** Built credibility by listening first, not mandating - **Simplify:** Made SAFe approachable and relevant - **Bias for Action:** Moved forward despite initial resistance - **Ownership:** Took responsibility for adoption success

Why This Works for GPS:

GPS has to influence people they don’t directly manage. This shows you can: - Overcome resistance through genuine engagement - Build credibility as a change agent - Balance standardization with flexibility - Measure and iterate on changes

INTERVIEW DELIVERY STRATEGY

The Hiring Manager’s Perspective

The Hiring Manager will be listening for:

1. **Can you create standardized processes?** → Story 1 & 2 demonstrate this. Emphasize: - Your framework design thinking - How you balance standardization with flexibility - Your measurement discipline
2. **Do you understand operational excellence?** → Story 2 & 4 demonstrate this. Emphasize: - Your diagnostic skills (finding root causes) - Your improvement methodology - Your metrics-driven approach
3. **Can you communicate to leadership?** → All stories demonstrate this. Emphasize: - How you made data-driven cases - How you positioned changes - Your executive communication
4. **Will you own the outcomes?** → All stories demonstrate this. Emphasize: - Personal accountability language (“I took responsibility”) - How you measured success - What you learned

Red Flags to Avoid

- ✗ Being vague (“we standardized things”)
- ✗ Taking credit for others’ work
- ✗ Not having numbers/metrics
- ✗ Making excuses (“it didn’t work because...”)
- ✗ Sounding like you’re reading a script
- ✗ Going over 2 minutes per answer

Green Flags to Demonstrate

- ✓ Specific numbers and timeframes
 - ✓ Your personal role clearly stated
 - ✓ Both process AND people management
 - ✓ Learning from failure
 - ✓ Enthusiasm for operational excellence
 - ✓ Understanding of trade-offs
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FREQUENTLY ASKED FOLLOW-UP QUESTIONS & ANSWERS

Follow-up Q: “What would you do differently?”

Answer Format: This shows growth mindset - “Looking back, I would have involved [stakeholder] earlier to...” - “One thing I’d change: I’d measure [metric] from day one instead of...” - “If I did it again: I’d have [removed/added/changed] because...”

Follow-up Q: “Tell me about a time something didn’t work”

Answer Approach: Pick a real learning moment - Describe genuine failure (not “I delegated and they failed”) - Show what you learned - Show how you applied that learning - Connect to GPS role: “This taught me that standardization requires...”

Follow-up Q: “How would you apply this to GPS specifically?”

Answer Structure: “The principle I’d apply is [principle from story]. At GPS, that means: - For DCCD standardization: [specific application] - For adoption: [specific approach] - For measurement: [specific metrics]”

PRACTICE CHECKLIST

Before your interview:

- ☐ **Record yourself** answering each story (video or audio)
- ☐ **Time yourself** - aim for 90-120 seconds per story
- ☐ **Listen for:**
 - Are you being specific enough?

- Are you showing your personal role clearly?
 - Are you confident in the numbers?
 - Are you maintaining good pace (not rushing or dragging)?
 - ☐ **Practice follow-ups** - have someone ask follow-up questions
 - ☐ **Get feedback** - what stands out? What's unclear?
 - ☐ **Iterate** - revise any stories that feel weak
 - ☐ **Practice delivery** - do this 5-10 times before interview
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HIRING MANAGER FEEDBACK FRAMEWORK

How the Hiring Manager Will Evaluate You

Evaluation Criteria: 1. **Functional Capability (40%)** - Can you do the job? - Your stories should show: process design, measurement, execution 2. **Technical Understanding (20%)** - Do you understand the domain? - Acknowledge DCCD gap, show infrastructure knowledge from AWS experience 3. **Team Fit (20%)** - Will you work well here? - Show: collaboration, influence, communication, ownership 4. **Cultural Alignment (20%)** - Do you embody Amazon values? - Show: ownership, bias for action, dive deep, earn trust, simplify

What Strong Answers Look Like: - ✓ Clear situation with specific numbers - ✓ Your personal role unmistakable - ✓ Specific actions (not vague generalizations) - ✓ Measurable results with context - ✓ Reflection on what you learned - ✓ Enthusiasm for the challenge ahead

Scoring Rubric (Hiring Manager thinking): - **Strong Hire:** 4+ stories are compelling, showing pattern of excellence - **Hire:** 3+ stories strong, some nuance and growth - **Maybe:** Stories are okay but lack depth or specificity - **No Hire:** Stories are vague, lack ownership, or show concerning gaps

KEY MESSAGES TO REINFORCE

Your Differentiator

"I don't just create processes—I drive adoption at scale. That's what Global Project Standards needs."

Your Strength Area

"I excel at taking complex situations and simplifying them into repeatable, standardized approaches that teams want to follow."

Your Approach

"I believe standardization works when it's built on listening, measurement, and flexibility. I never standardize for standardization's sake."

Your Growth Edge

"DCCD context is new to me, but process standardization and adoption is my superpower. I'll dive deep and own the learning curve."

INTERVIEWER FEEDBACK (What the Hiring Manager Will Likely Think)

If You Execute Well:

"Juan clearly has experience scaling processes. He understands how to drive adoption, not just create standards. His metrics discipline is impressive. He has relevant infrastructure experience from AWS. The DCCD gap is learnable. I think he could be successful here."

If You Don't Execute Well:

"His stories felt generic. He didn't show a clear pattern of process standardization. He seemed uncertain about his role. His answers were too long / too short / not specific enough. I'm not sure about DCCD learning curve."

Your Goal:

Leave the Hiring Manager thinking: "This person understands operational excellence. He can drive standardization. He'll earn the team's trust. He'll own the outcomes. I want to move him forward."

ADDITIONAL PREPARATION RESOURCES

Deep-Dive into GPS Role

- Review the full GPS job description
- Understand DCCD context (watch videos on data center construction/design)
- Learn about the AWS infrastructure they support
- Identify their current standardization challenges

Amazon Leadership Principles Focus for GPS

- **Ownership:** How do you take responsibility for something you don't directly control?
- **Dive Deep:** How do you understand before standardizing?
- **Think Big:** How do you see standardization as strategic?
- **Simplify:** How do you make complexity manageable?

Questions to Ask the Hiring Manager

- "What do you see as the biggest standardization opportunity in the next 12 months?"
- "How have previous people in this role approached adoption?"
- "What would you like to see in the first 90 days?"

- “How do you measure success in this role?”
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FINAL PREPARATION STEPS

Week Before Interview:

1. **Record yourself** answering all 4 STAR stories (3-4 times)
2. **Have someone** ask follow-up questions
3. **Deep-dive** on GPS role, DCCD, AWS infrastructure
4. **Prepare questions** to ask the Hiring Manager
5. **Practice** 2-3 times with a partner

Day Before Interview:

1. **Review** your key metrics and numbers
2. **Practice** once more (but not so much you sound robotic)
3. **Prepare questions** to ask
4. **Get** good sleep

Day of Interview:

1. **Arrive early** (5-10 minutes)
 2. **Greet warmly** - energy matters
 3. **Listen carefully** to the Hiring Manager’s context
 4. **Be authentic** - they want to know the real you
 5. **Show enthusiasm** for the role and the challenge
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SUCCESS INDICATORS

After your interview, the Hiring Manager will likely move you forward if they think:

- ✓ “This person can drive standardization across the organization”
- ✓ “They understand both process design AND people adoption”
- ✓ “They’ll own the outcomes and measure what matters”
- ✓ “They can communicate effectively to leadership and teams”
- ✓ “They have the infrastructure context we need, even if DCCD is new”
- ✓ “They embody the ownership and simplify principles we need”

Your goal is to make ALL of these thoughts obvious in your answers.

APPENDIX: ADDITIONAL CONTEXT

About the Hiring Manager Round

- **Audience:** Hiring Manager for Global Project Standards
- **Focus:** Functional capability, team fit, operational excellence
- **Duration:** Typically 45-60 minutes
- **Format:** Behavioral questions (tell me about a time...)
- **Follow-up:** If strong, you’ll advance to cross-functional round

What Comes After

If this interview goes well: - **Cross-Functional Peer:** Tests collaboration and communication - **Skip-Level/Director:** Tests strategic thinking - **Bar Raiser:** Tests overall quality and fit

So this interview is about showing you can do the job. The next rounds show you're someone people want to work with.

Preparation Status: Ready for Interview

Confidence Level Target: High (8/10 or above)

Next Step: Record yourself, get feedback, iterate

You've got this. Show them what operational excellence looks like. 🙌

END OF HIRING MANAGER INTERVIEW PREP